

■ By Nirmala Ravindran

Taking literary circles by storm, the trio of Kutty Revathi, Salma, and Malathy Maitri have not only revolutionised feminist poetry in Tamil Nadu, but also reclaimed the woman's voice at considerable cost. When 32-year-old Revathi's book of poems titled *Mulaigal* (Breasts) was published in 2002, there was a frenzy of demands that the books be burnt, and the poet be flogged and ostracised. Ironically, the most vociferous protests came from lyricists of popular Tamil cinema, some of whom advocated that Revathi and others of her tribe be burnt on Chennai's Mount Road.

The petite and soft-spoken Revathi, besides being a poet, is a practitioner of Siddha medicine and the editor of the Tamil literary quarterly *Panikkudam*. She says all she sought to explore was breasts as a 'living inhabited reality', rather than an 'exhibited commodity' in the commercial world. What enraged the sensibilities of a conservative Tamil society was the use of words like *mulai-gal*, *yoni* (vagina), *kamam* (lust) and *suyap-punarchi* (masturbation)—in short, everything that had to do with a woman's body and sexuality.

The search for a female voice in Tamil literature began in the '70s with stalwarts like Ambai (C.S. Lakshmi). What unites the brigade is the fact that they write about

women's bodies—something a patriarchal society feels they should not do. "Why don't you write about environmental issues instead?" is a question the poets are often asked. Separated geographically—Revathi lives in Chennai, Salma in Trichy and Malathy Maitri is from Puducherry—the poets meet only at literary events. But the witch hunt led them to form an organisation, *Anangu*, to oppose the patriarchy gunning for them.

A founder-member of *Anangu*, 39-year-old Maitri is a firm advocate for fighting the system that will not allow them the space to speak of their bodies and their identities. In a victory of sorts, she sent a legal notice to film lyricist Palani Bharathi who wrote defamatory articles about her in a Tamil weekly and forced him to tender a public apology. Her poems speak of violence against women and how to deal with it—*Speaking in your dialect/Or without words/Or even if you are crying/Simply extend your hand/Place it in between the thighs/And pull with all your strength/His testicles*.

Besides writing poetry, Salma, 39, is also actively involved in politics in Trichy. Prevented from getting an education when young, Salma has been ostracised by her husband and in-laws for her writing. Whether it is Maitri's activism, Salma's simplicity or Revathi's surrealism, what these women ultimately seek is a new voice and a lost identity.

DEFIANT SPIRIT: Maitri (left); Salma

"TO BE ABLE TO TALK ABOUT YOUR BODY IS TO BE FREE, AND THAT IS SOMETHING MEN SEEM INSECURE ABOUT."

SALMA,
POET AND POLITICIAN

"NOTHING HAS CHANGED IN SOCIETY, NOT THE MEN, AND CERTAINLY NOT THE WOMEN. TILL WE FIND A VOICE AND RECLAIM AN IDENTITY, IT WILL BE A STRUGGLE."

MALATHY MAITRI,
FOUNDER-MEMBER, *ANANGU*



Photographs by H.K. Rajeshkar